

How You Speak and Write: How to Write a Book: 13 Steps From a Bestselling Author

Various speakers

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Chapter 1

How to Write a Book: 13 Steps From a Bestselling Author

This lecture unfolds as a deliberate sequence of constraints and releases. We begin where the lecturer begins: against the easy internet promise that a book can be produced quickly by a gimmick. Then, step by step, we move from working conditions to scale, from scale to structure, from structure to readerly motion, and finally from drafting freedom to ruthless revision. What emerges is not a bag of tips but a disciplined model of how a long manuscript is built.

1.1 Quality First: Space, Tools, and the Refusal of Excuses

The lecture opens polemically. There are many promises of speed, many formulas for instant success, many compressed recipes for producing a bestseller. The speaker rejects that atmosphere at once. He does not promise a bestseller, and he does not promise speed. He promises thirteen foundational steps. The governing contrast can be written compactly as

$$\text{speed} \neq \text{goal}, \quad \text{quality} = \text{goal}. \quad (1.1)$$

This relation sets the tone of everything that follows. If quality is the goal, then our first concern is not acceleration but the conditions under which sustained work becomes possible.

That is why the lecture begins so concretely. We establish a writing space. Then we assemble writing tools. These first steps are not glamorous, but they are meant to eliminate the beginner's favorite alibi. The speaker is explicit: we should not say that we have no place to write. A plank laid across chairs once served as a desk. A restaurant can serve. A car can serve. A noisy newsroom once served. The point is not that ideal conditions are irrelevant; the point is that work begins under conditions that are merely workable.

The same seriousness applies to tools. We do not need an elaborate apparatus, but we do need enough stability to keep from breaking concentration every few minutes. A computer that does not fight us, a chair that does not punish the back and neck, and the ordinary materials that would otherwise send us searching across the room all belong to the same logic. Before any large project can move, we reduce friction.

1.1.1 Question & Answer

Question. Do we need ideal conditions before we begin?

Answer. No. The lecture distinguishes ideal conditions from usable conditions. Privacy, silence, and better equipment help, but their absence does not excuse delay. We need a place and a setup that can recur. The operative word is not perfect; it is established.

1.2 Breaking the Scale of the Problem and Testing the Idea

Once the local conditions are fixed, the lecture raises the next obstacle. A book is large enough to intimidate by sheer mass. The speaker does not answer this with inspiration. He answers it by changing the scale at which we think. A book is not attacked as a five-hundred-page object. It is reduced to units:

$$\text{book} \rightarrow \text{chapters} \rightarrow \text{paragraphs} \rightarrow \text{sentences.} \quad (1.2)$$

That reduction is the practical content of the elephant analogy. We do not consume the whole at once. We consume the next piece.

The point may also be written more schematically:

$$\text{colossal task} \Rightarrow \text{small actionable units.} \quad (1.3)$$

The lecture lingers here because this is the first major psychological reversal. The book remains large, but the writer's next action becomes small.

At this point, however, the lecturer refuses an easy conclusion. Not every project deserves rescue by perseverance. Some ideas are too small for the form they are being asked to occupy. Hence Step 4: settle on a big idea. The distinction is not vague. A small concept belongs in a blog post or article. A large concept belongs in a book.

$$\text{small concept} \Rightarrow \text{blog/article,} \quad \text{big concept} \Rightarrow \text{book.} \quad (1.4)$$

The speaker makes this vivid by naming examples rather than by speaking abstractly. For nonfiction he invokes *How to Win Friends and Influence People*; for fiction he invokes *Harry Potter*. The point is not imitation. It is scale.

1.2.1 Question & Answer

Question. How do we know whether an idea has enough legs for a book?

Answer. The lecture gives a pragmatic test. We tell the idea to another person. If it keeps getting bigger in the retelling, it likely has the required scope. If it repeatedly hits the same wall, then the trouble is not stamina. The trouble is that the idea itself is undersized.

1.3 Outline, Fiction and Nonfiction, and the Marathon of the Middle

At Step 5 the lecture reaches its first structural summit. The whiteboard matters because it captures the talk at the moment when a collection of practical rules becomes a theory of shape.

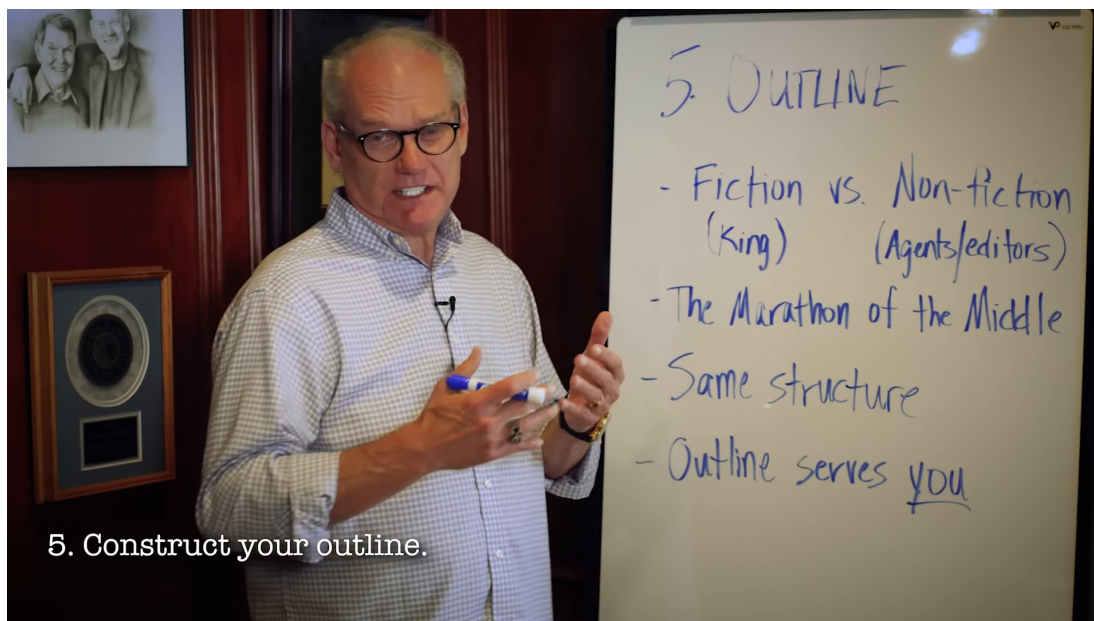


Figure 1.1: Whiteboard outline for Step 5: fiction, nonfiction, the middle, and the role of the outline.

In cleaned typeset form, the board reads

5. OUTLINE

Fiction vs. Non-fiction	(King)	(Agents/editors)
The Marathon of the Middle		
Same structure		
Outline serves <u>you</u> .		

The lecturer begins from a tension he knows the audience will feel. If some fiction writers work as pantsers, writing by discovery rather than by detailed plan, why insist on an outline? His answer is careful. The degree of outlining may vary, but direction cannot disappear. Stephen King stands for one pole: interesting characters placed in difficult situations, with the writing used to discover what happens. Even there, however, some sense of direction remains necessary. Nonfiction lies at the opposite pole. There the writer is answerable to agents and editors who want to know what will be said, how it will be said, what the sources are, and where the argument is going.

This is why the board's next claim matters so much: *same structure*. The surface resources differ across genres, but the underlying motion does not. The lecture gives that shared law a simple form:

$$\text{setup} \rightarrow \text{payoff.} \quad (1.5)$$

This is the real mathematical spine of the chapter. Fiction often realizes the pattern through scenes, dialogue, reversal, and conflict. Nonfiction may realize it through problem, method, explanation, and result. But in both cases the reader is carried by planted expectation and later fulfillment.

Definition 1.1. The Marathon of the Middle is the portion of a manuscript, usually somewhere between the halfway point and the three-quarter point, where the writer feels the drag of length and the temptation to pad, abandon, or merely endure.

As a compact editorial shorthand, we may write

$$x \in \left[\frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{4}\right] \Rightarrow \text{heightened risk of structural fatigue}, \quad (1.6)$$

while remembering that the variable x is our own summary, not a symbol used in the lecture.

The lecturer's strongest claim here is that one must not merely survive the middle. One must thrive there. If the middle seems boring to us, the reader is already asleep. That principle applies to nonfiction just as much as to fiction. A nonfiction book about building a model ship should not merely enumerate instructions; it should set up difficulty in such a way that the eventual solution feels earned.

1.3.1 Question & Answer

Question. If we are pantsers, why do we still need an outline?

Answer. Because discovery is not the same as aimlessness. A fiction writer may outline lightly, and a nonfiction writer may outline heavily, but in both cases the outline gives direction to a long form that would otherwise sprawl. The lecture's final corrective is equally important: the outline is an instrument. It serves the book, and the book serves the writer. If the developing manuscript proves better than the original scheme, we change the outline rather than subordinating the book to it.

1.4 Schedule, Deadlines, and Research as Control Variables

Having established structure, the lecture returns to execution. Step 6 turns the will to write into arithmetic. The writer estimates the total size of the manuscript, estimates the days available, and divides:

$$\text{daily quota} = \frac{\text{target pages or words}}{\text{days available}}. \quad (1.7)$$

The significance of this formula is not numerical elegance. It is moral clarity. A deadline becomes real only when it has been converted into a daily obligation.

The lecture is equally practical about adjustment. We may begin by estimating ten pages per day and then discover that four or five is closer to reality. In that case the schedule may be revised. But once revised and fixed, it becomes sacred. The mistake is to believe that time for writing will be found accidentally. The lecture says the opposite: something else in the day must be sacrificed.

Worked example. The speaker gives a concrete case from his own schedule:

$$70,000 - 67,500 = 2,500, \quad (1.8)$$

$$\text{tomorrow's quota} = 2,500 \text{ words}. \quad (1.9)$$

The calculation is elementary, but the point is not elementary. It is the transformation of a vague ambition into a sharp demand.

The lecturer adds a sobering publishing heuristic:

$$\text{deadline keepers} \approx \frac{1}{100}. \quad (1.10)$$

This is not a theorem. It is a professional estimate meant to raise the standard of seriousness. To keep a deadline is already to distinguish oneself from most writers.

Step 7 then broadens the discussion from schedule to knowledge. Research is obviously necessary in nonfiction, but the lecturer insists that many writers underestimate its importance in fiction. A missed detail in history, aircraft, or weaponry will be noticed immediately by readers who know the subject. The lecture's governing metaphor is exact:

$$\text{research} \neq \text{main course}, \quad \text{research} = \text{seasoning}. \quad (1.11)$$

That metaphor preserves the hierarchy. Research supplies specificity and credibility; it does not replace story. The lecturer offers a concrete example from his own work: he is using a world-history chart spanning 2000 B.C. to the present in order to track births, deaths, and overlaps accurately. The research exists to support the narrative line, not to swamp it.

1.4.1 Question & Answer

Question. How much research is enough before it starts taking over the book?

Answer. Enough to make the work specific, believable, and technically secure, but not so much that the reader is made to admire the writer's note cards. Research has done its job when it sharpens the page without becoming the page's subject.

1.5 Reader-First Openers and the Logic of Tension

With structure, schedule, and research in place, the lecture turns decisively toward the reader. Step 8 begins with the opening line. The point is not that the first line is magical. The point is that it fixes tone and establishes pressure. The lecturer names several categories of opener:

$$\{\text{surprising, dramatic, philosophical, poetic}\}. \quad (1.12)$$

He then gives examples. Orwell's opening in *1984* is used to illustrate a surprise that immediately destabilizes the world. Elizabeth Gilbert's nonfiction example uses sharp, concrete action to the same end. Toni Morrison's famous opening in *Paradise* stands for the dramatic statement. The lecture does not stay at the level of example for long. It converts the local issue of the first line into a global rule.

That rule is the reader-first filter:

$$\text{decision} \xrightarrow{\text{reader first}} \{\text{keep, revise, cut}\}. \quad (1.13)$$

The lecturer says this directly: every decision in the manuscript should pass through the question of what it does for the reader. Not writer first. Not editor first. Not critic first. Reader first. This is

one of the strongest conceptual turns in the talk. The opener is important not as ornament, but because it teaches us how all later decisions are to be judged.

Step 9 extends that principle from the opening line to the life of the whole manuscript. What keeps a reader turning pages? The lecture's answer is pressure:

$$\text{conflict/tension} \Rightarrow \text{page-turning momentum.} \quad (1.14)$$

For fiction the explanation is vivid. Pleasant agreement may be nice in life, but on the page it often dies. The scene comes alive when some buried strain appears, when one character says the unexpected thing, when the surface conversation no longer explains itself.

Nonfiction, however, is not exempt. The lecturer explicitly asks how tension appears there. His answer is structural rather than theatrical:

$$\text{promise} \rightarrow \text{delivery.} \quad (1.15)$$

A strong nonfiction book spends early pages promising what the reader will possess by the end, and then it must deliver exactly that. Tension, in this context, is not battle. It is deferred fulfillment.

1.5.1 Question & Answer

Question. How do we create tension in nonfiction without literal villains, battles, or melodrama?

Answer. By giving the reader something to wait for. We pose a difficulty, an impossibility, or a desired transformation, and then we organize the manuscript so that later chapters fulfill what earlier chapters promised. In nonfiction, tension is often simply the disciplined spacing between announcement and arrival.

1.6 Drafting Freedom, the Return of the Middle, and the Resounding Ending

Step 10 changes the temporal register. Until now the lecture has mostly described structure from outside. Now it asks what the writer should permit during the act of drafting. The answer is severe and liberating at once: turn off the internal editor.

$$\text{draft with editor off} \rightarrow \text{return later to edit} \rightarrow \text{cut to add power.} \quad (1.16)$$

The sequence matters. A first draft is not the place to litigate every word. The lecturer says this in personal terms: the inner critic sits on the shoulder and objects to everything. During drafting that critic must be silenced. The purpose of the first draft is to get the material down.

1.6.1 Question & Answer

Question. When should the internal editor be silent, and when should it return?

Answer. It should be silent while the draft is being produced, because early criticism destroys continuity. It should return only later, preferably after some time has passed, when the writer can look at the manuscript as something to be shaped rather than something still struggling to come into existence.

At this point the lecture performs one of its most important recaps. Step 11 explicitly returns to the Marathon of the Middle. This is not repetition for its own sake. It is the moment where an earlier structural principle is reintroduced as a recurring lived crisis. The lecturer says plainly that this is the place he himself wants to quit. The danger is padding: extra scenes in fiction, extra points in nonfiction, material that prolongs length without increasing pressure.

The answer is again to thrive rather than endure. The middle must continue to carry real setup and payoff. In the lecturer's own current work in progress, one strategy for keeping the middle alive is to alternate between 2000 B.C., the present day, and Vietnam, so that the manuscript keeps renewing its own pressure rather than flattening into a single band of exposition.

Step 12 then turns toward closure. An ending must not fizzle. It must land with the firmness of a curtain coming down in a theater. If several endings are possible, the lecture's rule is clear:

candidate endings → choose the most emotional. (1.17)

This does not mean sentimentality. It means that readers remember what moves them, and the last movement of the book must therefore gather the force that has been prepared all along.

1.7 Ferocious Self-Editing and Professional Judgment

The final movement of the lecture tightens the standard one last time. We are told to become ferocious self-editors. The word is not mystical. It means aggressive. We cut. We polish. We make the manuscript sing. If we do not do this work ourselves, everything else has been partly wasted.

The lecturer then introduces the professional pressure under which manuscripts are actually read. Agents and editors have too much to read and too little time. Very often they can tell within two minutes, or within a page or two, whether a manuscript deserves further attention. The logic is harsh but simple. Competition is vast, so the opening pages must arrive already sharpened. Self-editing is therefore not a decorative last step. It is the act by which the book is made ready to meet the world without apology.

At the end the lecture circles back to its own beginning. It began by rejecting shortcuts and speed-hype. It ends by showing what stands in their place: working conditions, a big idea, an outline, a schedule, research, reader-first judgment, tension, a free draft, a middle that thrives, an ending that lands, and an editor ruthless enough to cut until the manuscript carries its full force.

1.8 Summary

The lecture advances one step at a time, but its force lies in the way the steps accumulate. We begin by removing excuses and establishing conditions for work. We reduce the scale of the problem, then test whether the concept is large enough to deserve a book. We outline, not as slaves to a scheme, but as writers who need direction through a long form. We convert ambition into quotas, use research as seasoning rather than display, and judge every local decision by the reader's experience.

We write the draft before we edit it, survive the middle by making it alive, choose the ending that moves most deeply, and finally revise with ferocity. The lecture's seriousness comes from a simple truth: a book is not wished into existence. It is built, sustained, and sharpened.